

Q My doctor said we might want to consider having ICSI rather than normal IVF treatment. What is it?

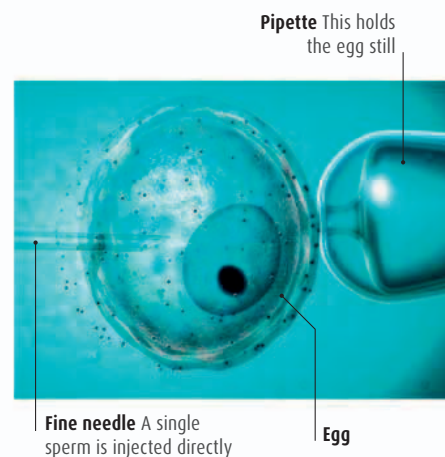
This is only different from IVF at the point of fertilization. Instead of the egg and sperm being left to fertilize naturally in a petri dish, one healthy sperm is selected and injected directly into a mature egg.

ICSI (intra-cytoplasmic sperm injection) is recommended to couples if the man has a very low sperm count, for example, or other sperm problems that mean the egg is unlikely to be fertilized naturally. This treatment may be recommended if you have had low—or even zero—fertilization rates in a previous IVF cycle—the eggs that have been collected have failed to turn into embryos in the first 24 hours.

The process of stimulating the ovaries to produce more eggs and egg collection is the same as for IVF. Following the ICSI fertilization procedure, the IVF treatment continues as normal in that the embryo (or embryos) is placed into the uterus (see opposite). Be aware that if you are paying for your IVF treatment, there is an additional expense for ICSI.

ICSI

In the ICSI procedure, the sperm and egg are brought together instead of being left to fertilize naturally.



Q I know someone who got pregnant by having IUI. What exactly is it?

IUI stands for intrauterine insemination and is a procedure where sperm is placed directly into the uterus. Before being considered for IUI, your fallopian tubes are tested to ensure that they are open. You are given a blood or urine test to detect ovulation. As soon as the egg is mature, a hormone injection is given to release it. Then 36–40 hours after this your partner provides a sperm sample. The fastest-moving, least-sluggish sperm are selected and inserted into your uterus using a catheter. It is a quick and painless procedure.

The rest is left to nature in the hope that one sperm fertilizes the egg. You may be advised to have up to six cycles of IUI. You may be recommended to opt for IUI if you have ovulation problems, your partner is impotent, or you are trying to get pregnant using donated sperm. IUI may or may not be covered by your health insurance company.

Q We're using donor eggs. Will my body naturally accept them?

If you are not ovulating (an inability to produce eggs is not rare) and require a donated egg, the lining of your uterus probably won't be thick enough for an embryo to implant in it. You will

need a cycle of hormone replacement prior to the egg being implanted to ensure the uterine lining can nourish the embryo. This is the main key to a successful pregnancy from a donated egg. The principle risk for you is a multiple birth if you have more than one fertilized egg transferred.

Q I've heard that some women freeze their eggs. Is this something I should consider doing?

Freezing and storing your eggs may enable you to use them for treatment in the future. Since many women are leaving childbearing to later in life, egg freezing is becoming more common. Aside from preserving fertility, it is something that is recommended for women under 40 who need cancer treatment that may make them infertile or for those who cannot wait for another IVF attempt (due to age or illness) if the first one fails. The procedure for collecting eggs is the same as the first stages of a cycle of IVF treatment where drugs are used to stimulate the ovaries to produce follicles (which contain the eggs). When the follicles are large enough, the eggs are retrieved and placed in storage in liquid nitrogen. Until relatively recently, using eggs that had been frozen carried certain risks and the success rate had been poor. Due to improved freezing methods (vitrification), this is now changing.

Women undergoing IVF or ICSI often have a number of unused embryos. Some people choose

to have these frozen for use in another treatment cycle if the first fails, to attempt another pregnancy with a sibling embryo, or to donate to others. The chances of a successful pregnancy using a thawed frozen embryo are not affected by the amount of time the embryo is stored and frozen. However, not all embryos survive the thawing process. The clinic will advise you on the best procedure for using your frozen embryos. There are options depending on your personal and medical circumstances.

There have been lawsuits in the US recently regarding the fate of frozen embryos after a couple splits up, since both partners contributed to the embryo. If you are considering freezing embryos with your partner, you may want to sign a contract or consent form to spell out what would happen to the embryos in the event that the relationship ended.



Did you know...

Eating oysters is good for male fertility. They are high in zinc, which helps sperm count, sperm motility (the way sperm moves), and increases testosterone levels. If you can't stomach oysters, other good sources of zinc are legumes, nuts, spinach, and lean beef and lamb, or you could take a daily zinc supplement.